

Sinornithosaurus

Sinornithosaurus was an early member of the dromaeosaur family. As this beautiful fossil shows, its entire body was covered from head to tail with feathers. *Sinornithosaurus* means “Chinese bird lizard,” but this species wasn’t a true bird, since it was probably too heavy to fly, although like other dromaeosaurs it may have evolved from a flying ancestor.

Sinornithosaurus

sine-OR-nith-oh-SORE-us

- **When** 130–125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** China
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 3 ft (1 m)
- **Diet** Probably omnivorous

Several well-preserved fossils of *Sinornithosaurus* have been found in China since 1999, including the amazingly complete fossil shown here (nicknamed “Dave”), which shows the precise distribution of feathers on the body. *Sinornithosaurus* was a ground-dwelling predator that hunted small animals, including other dinosaurs. Although it couldn’t fly, some scientists think it could climb trees.

Fossil fish

Venomous or not?

In 2009, scientists noticed something strange about *Sinornithosaurus*: it had unusually long, fanglike teeth with prominent grooves, similar to those of venomous snakes and lizards today. They suggested that *Sinornithosaurus* was venomous (able to inject poison into prey with a bite or a sting). Other scientists disagree with this theory, saying that these grooves could simply be normal wear and tear, and that other dinosaurs had grooved teeth, too.